

The Moon and Mars Project

Vocabulary, Grammar, and Comprehension Handout

Intermediate Level

THE TEXT

Before becoming a research pharmacist, I had never imagined that writing a proposal could be such a devastating task. Over the past two weeks, I have drafted four different versions, and none of them have worked out. The reason is not that the prospects behind these proposals lack promise — in fact, each one held the potential to make a meaningful contribution to the field. Rather, the real-world scenario simply does not allow me to obtain the data or resources I need to carry the work forward. After countless revisions and discussions with colleagues, I finally settled on a proposal that requires no financial support but demands that I build everything from scratch — including the methodology itself, since no one on earth has ever attempted this kind of study before.

Although I know that if I reach the goal I have set out to achieve, the reward would be far greater than I can imagine, the uncertainty of whether I am truly capable of accomplishing it still weighs on me. There are nights when I lie awake wondering whether I have set the bar too high, or whether I am underestimating the obstacles that lie ahead. This concern grew even heavier when my boss offered a second opinion: he gently suggested that I look for something less novel but more achievable, given the strict one-year deadline imposed by the program. He worried that such rigid time constraints might stifle genuine innovation and ultimately lead me somewhere far from where I truly want to go. His words made sense, yet a part of me was reluctant to give up on the original vision that had inspired me in the first place.

It was not until the end of this week that I seemed to find the middle ground I had been searching for. I happened to come across an article that introduced me to an idea I had

never considered before — and to my surprise, this concept could solve the preliminary problem I had been struggling to address in my proposal. The more I read, the more I realized how naturally it fit with the questions I had been asking. If I apply this method and treat the preliminary problem as a “moon project,” it would provide valuable insight into the clinical issue and help me form a better strategy to confront the larger problem I am determined to solve. As for my original, more ambitious proposal, perhaps I can regard it as a “Mars project.” If I have the chance to land on Mars one day, it will be an incredible journey filled with discovery. But even if I never reach that distant destination, at least I will still have completed a meaningful piece of research by landing safely on the moon — and sometimes, that is exactly where the most important steps begin.

PART A: VOCABULARY (12 Words)

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	devastating (adj.)	causing great shock, distress, or difficulty. "...writing a proposal could be such a devastating task."
2	draft (v.)	to write a first or preliminary version of something. "I have drafted four different versions."
3	prospect (n.)	the possibility or likelihood of a future event; chance of success. "...the prospects behind these proposals lack promise."
4	scenario (n.)	a possible situation or sequence of events. "...the real-world scenario simply does not allow me..."
5	methodology (n.)	a system of methods used in a particular area of study or activity. "...building everything from scratch — including the methodology itself."
6	uncertainty (n.)	the state of being unsure or doubtful. "...the uncertainty of whether I am truly capable..."
7	underestimate (v.)	to think or guess that something is smaller or less important than it really is. "...I am underestimating the obstacles that lie ahead."
8	stifle (v.)	to prevent something from happening or developing; to suppress. "...such rigid time constraints might stifle genuine innovation."
9	rigid (adj.)	strict, fixed, and not easily changed. "...such rigid time constraints..."
10	reluctant (adj.)	unwilling or hesitant to do something. "...a part of me was reluctant to give up on the original vision."
11	ambitious (adj.)	having or showing a strong desire to achieve great things. "As for my original, more ambitious proposal..."
12	confront (v.)	to face or deal with a problem or difficulty directly. "...help me form a better strategy to confront the larger problem."

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. The hurricane was so _____ that the entire coastal town needed to be rebuilt.
 - a) ambitious
 - b) devastating
 - c) reluctant
 - d) rigid
2. She decided to _____ a letter before sending the final version to her professor.
 - a) confront
 - b) stifle
 - c) draft
 - d) underestimate
3. The _____ of finding a stable job after graduation made him work harder.
 - a) prospect
 - b) methodology
 - c) scenario
 - d) uncertainty
4. We must consider every possible _____ before launching the new product.
 - a) prospect
 - b) scenario
 - c) methodology
 - d) reluctance
5. The researcher developed a new _____ to measure brain activity more accurately.
 - a) uncertainty
 - b) prospect
 - c) methodology
 - d) draft

6. Many students live with the _____ of not knowing which career path to choose.

- a) confrontation
- b) ambition
- c) methodology
- d) uncertainty

7. Don't _____ how difficult this exam can be — you should start preparing now.

- a) underestimate
- b) confront
- c) draft
- d) stifle

8. Strict rules in the classroom can sometimes _____ children's creativity.

- a) draft
- b) stifle
- c) confront
- d) underestimate

9. The teacher's _____ schedule left no room for spontaneous discussion.

- a) reluctant
- b) ambitious
- c) rigid
- d) devastating

10. He was _____ to share his idea because he feared others might laugh.

- a) ambitious
- b) reluctant
- c) rigid
- d) devastating

11. Her _____ goal is to start her own company before turning thirty.

- a) reluctant
- b) rigid
- c) ambitious
- d) devastating

12. Sooner or later, you will have to _____ your fear of public speaking.

- a) stifle
- b) draft
- c) underestimate
- d) confront

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

devastating draft prospect scenario methodology uncertainty
underestimate stifle rigid reluctant ambitious confront

1. After years of avoiding the topic, she finally decided to _____ her father about their disagreement.
2. Heavy rules and pressure can _____ even the most creative minds.
3. The team chose a new research _____ to make their results more reliable.
4. The _____ of winning the championship motivated the players to train every day.
5. There is always some _____ when you start a brand-new project.
6. He was _____ to leave his hometown because all his family lived there.
7. Never _____ the power of a kind word at the right moment.
8. The earthquake had a _____ effect on the small mountain village.
9. She spent the whole night trying to _____ a speech for the wedding.
10. His _____ daily schedule leaves no time for relaxation.
11. The young scientist set herself an _____ goal: to publish three papers in one year.
12. In the worst-case _____, the company might have to close two of its branches.

PART B: GRAMMAR (4 Patterns)

Study the following grammar structures from the text.

Pattern 1: “none of + plural noun + has/have + past participle”

Form: None of + plural noun + has/have + past participle...

Use: To express that not even one item from a group did something.

Example from text: “I have drafted four different versions, and none of them have worked out.”

More examples:

- None of my friends have seen that movie yet.
- None of the students have finished the homework on time.
- None of these solutions has solved the problem completely.

Pattern 2: “no one has ever + past participle”

Form: No one + has/had ever + past participle + ...

Use: To emphasize that an action has never been performed by anyone before.

Example from text: “...no one on earth has ever attempted this kind of study before.”

More examples:

- No one has ever climbed that mountain in winter.
- No one had ever spoken to her so kindly before.
- No one in our class has ever scored a perfect mark on this test.

Pattern 3: “There are + time/situation + when + clause”

Form: There are + nights/days/times/moments + when + subject + verb

Use: To describe recurring moments during which something happens.

Example from text: "There are nights when I lie awake wondering whether I have set the bar too high."

More examples:

- There are days when I just want to stay in bed and read.
- There are moments when silence speaks louder than words.
- There are times when even adults need someone to listen to them.

Pattern 4: "given + noun phrase" for reason or condition

Form: Main clause, + given + noun phrase

Use: To introduce a reason or condition that is already known or accepted.

Example from text: "...he gently suggested that I look for something less novel but more achievable, given the strict one-year deadline."

More examples:

- We should leave early, given the heavy traffic in the morning.
- The result is impressive, given how little time he had to prepare.
- Given her age, she has accomplished an incredible amount.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. _____ of the answers were correct on the first try.
 - a) Some
 - b) None
 - c) All
 - d) Most
2. None of the players _____ ready for the final match.
 - a) is
 - b) was
 - c) are
 - d) being
3. None of these methods _____ produced reliable results so far.
 - a) have
 - b) has
 - c) is
 - d) were
4. No one in this town _____ ever seen such a strange sky before.
 - a) have
 - b) has
 - c) had been
 - d) is
5. No one _____ ever spoken to her so harshly before that day.
 - a) has
 - b) had
 - c) have
 - d) is

6. There are mornings _____ I just want to stay under the blanket.
- a) which
 - b) where
 - c) when
 - d) what
7. _____ are moments when a single word can change everything.
- a) It
 - b) These
 - c) There
 - d) That
8. There are weekends _____ I do absolutely nothing, and I love it.
- a) which
 - b) when
 - c) where
 - d) that
9. We should call a taxi, _____ how late it is.
- a) given
 - b) giving
 - c) gave
 - d) gives
10. _____ his lack of experience, he handled the situation surprisingly well.
- a) Giving
 - b) Given
 - c) Gave
 - d) Gives
11. The performance was excellent, _____ how little time the team had to rehearse.
- a) given
 - b) giving
 - c) gives
 - d) gave

12. _____ of the four proposals has been accepted by the committee.

- a) None
- b) No one
- c) Nothing
- d) Nobody

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern indicated in parentheses.

none of + plural noun + has/have

1. Every one of my plans failed. (None of...)

none of + plural noun + has/have

2. Every test was easy for him. (None of the tests...)

none of + plural noun + has/have

3. All four candidates were rejected by the panel. (None of...)

no one has ever

4. Nobody in history has done what she did. (No one has ever...)

no one has ever

5. This is a completely new recipe — nobody has tried it. (No one has ever...)

no one has ever

6. Until now, no climber had reached this peak in winter. (No one had ever...)

There are + time + when

7. Sometimes I feel completely lost. (There are times...)

There are + time + when

8. On some weekends, the city becomes very quiet. (There are weekends...)

There are + time + when

9. Sometimes silence speaks more loudly than words. (There are moments...)

given + noun phrase

10. Considering the bad weather, the trip was a success. (... , given...)

given + noun phrase

11. Because of his small budget, his project was impressive. (... , given...)

given + noun phrase

12. Considering her young age, she has accomplished a great deal. (... , given...)

PART C: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions in complete sentences.

Tier 1 — Literal

1. How many versions of the proposal did the writer draft over the past two weeks?

2. What does the writer's final proposal require, and what does it not require?

3. What "second opinion" did the writer's boss offer, and why?

Tier 2 — Inference

4. Why might the writer have felt that her boss's suggestion "made sense" but still feel reluctant to follow it?

5. What does the writer mean when she says "no one on earth has ever attempted this kind of study before"? What does this reveal about her project?

Tier 3 — Critical Thinking

6. The writer uses the metaphor of “moon project” and “Mars project” to describe her two goals. Why is this comparison effective? What does each one represent?

7. Do you think the writer made the right decision in choosing the middle ground? Why or why not?

Tier 4 — Personal Response

8. The writer says, “sometimes, that is exactly where the most important steps begin.” Have you ever started something small that turned out to be more important than you expected? Describe it.

PART D: CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Theme: Setting goals, facing uncertainty, and finding balance between ambition and practicality.

1. When you set a goal, do you usually aim high like the writer's "Mars project," or do you prefer realistic targets like a "moon project"? Why?
2. Have you ever had to give up on an ambitious dream because of real-world limitations such as time, money, or resources? How did you feel about it?
3. When someone you respect (like a teacher, parent, or boss) gives you advice that contradicts your own vision, how do you decide whether to follow it?
4. The writer found her breakthrough by accidentally reading an article. Do you believe important ideas come to us by chance, or are they the result of constant searching?
5. If you had only one year to complete a meaningful project of your own choosing, what would it be — and would you play it safe or take a risk?

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b 2. c 3. a 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. a 8. b 9. c 10. b 11. c 12. d

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. confront
2. stifle
3. methodology
4. prospect
5. uncertainty
6. reluctant
7. underestimate
8. devastating
9. draft
10. rigid
11. ambitious
12. scenario

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b 2. c 3. a 4. b 5. b 6. c 7. c 8. b 9. a 10. b 11. a 12. a

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

1. None of my plans have worked out / have succeeded.
2. None of the tests have been difficult for him.

3. None of the four candidates have been accepted by the panel.
4. No one has ever done what she did (in history).
5. No one has ever tried this recipe before.
6. No one had ever reached this peak in winter.
7. There are times when I feel completely lost.
8. There are weekends when the city becomes very quiet.
9. There are moments when silence speaks more loudly than words.
10. The trip was a success, given the bad weather.
11. His project was impressive, given his small budget.
12. She has accomplished a great deal, given her young age.

Comprehension Questions — Suggested Answers

1. She drafted four different versions of the proposal.
2. The final proposal does not require any financial support, but it requires her to build everything from scratch, including the methodology, since no one has done this kind of study before.
3. He suggested she look for something less novel but more achievable, because he was worried that the strict one-year deadline would stifle innovation.
4. The boss's suggestion was practical and realistic, given the time limit, so it made sense logically. However, the writer was reluctant because she did not want to give up the original vision that had truly inspired her.
5. It means the study is completely new and has never been tried before. This shows that her project is highly innovative, but also full of risk and uncertainty because there is no existing methodology or experience to follow.

6. The metaphor compares two kinds of goals: the “moon project” is closer, more achievable, and provides solid information; the “Mars project” is more distant, ambitious, and uncertain, but holds greater potential reward. The comparison is effective because both are real space missions that people understand, and it shows how she balances ambition with practicality.

7. (Open answer.) Students may say yes — because she keeps her ambition alive while still making sure something useful is achieved — or no, depending on personal viewpoint.

8. (Open personal response.)